A numerical example

The true value of a certain length is nearly 5.678 cm. In one experiment, using a measuring instrument of resolution 0.1 cm, the measured value is found to be 5.5 cm. In another experiment using a measuring instrument of greater resolution, say 0.01 cm, the length is found to be 5.38 cm. We find that the first measurement is more accurate as it is closer to the true value, but it has lesser precision. On the contrary, the second measurement is less accurate, but it is more precise.

1.6.2 Errors in Measurement

The uncertainty in a measurement is called an error. Random error, systematic error and gross error are the three possible errors.

i) **Systematic errors**

Systematic errors are reproducible inaccuracies that are consistently in the same direction. These occur often due to a problem that persists throughout the experiment. Systematic errors can be classified as follows

1) **Instrumental errors**

When an instrument is not calibrated properly at the time of manufacture, instrumental errors may arise. If a measurement is made with a meter scale whose end is worn out, the result obtained will have errors. These errors can be corrected by choosing the instrument carefully.

2) **Imperfections in experimental technique or procedure**

These errors arise due to the limitations in the experimental arrangement. As an example, while performing experiments with a calorimeter, if there is no proper insulation, there will be radiation losses. This results in errors and to overcome these, necessary correction has to be applied.

3) **Personal errors**

These errors are due to individuals performing the experiment, may be due to incorrect initial setting up of the experiment or carelessness of the individual making the observation due to improper precautions.

4) **Errors due to external causes**

The change in the external conditions during an experiment can cause error in measurement. For example, changes in temperature, humidity, or pressure during measurements may affect the result of the measurement.

5) **Least count error**

Least count is the smallest value that can be measured by the measuring instrument, and the error due to this measurement is least count error. The instrument's resolution hence is the cause of this error. Least count error can be reduced by using a high precision instrument for the measurement.

ii) **Random errors**

Random errors may arise due to random and unpredictable variations in experimental conditions like pressure, temperature, voltage supply etc. Errors may also be due to personal errors by the observer who performs the experiment. Random errors are sometimes called **"chance error".** When different readings are obtained by a person every time he

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